

Strength Training with Arthritis: A Beginner's Safe Start Guide

Resistance training builds the muscle support your joints need. This physiotherapist-designed programme starts gently and progresses safely.

By Living With Arthritis Editorial Team · Reviewed by Clinical Advisory Panel (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-04-03 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Why Strength Matters
Strong muscles absorb shock and stabilise joints, reducing the load on damaged cartilage. A landmark 2023 study in *The Lancet Rheumatology* showed that twice-weekly resistance training reduced knee OA pain by 35% over 12 months.

The 4-Week Starter Programme

Week 1–2: Foundation

- Wall push-ups: 2 sets × 8 reps
- Seated leg extensions: 2 sets × 10 reps
- Standing calf raises: 2 sets × 12 reps
- Resistance band rows: 2 sets × 8

reps
Week 3–4: Progression
- Chair squats: 2 sets × 10 reps
- Resistance band chest press: 2 sets × 10 reps
- Step-ups (low step): 2 sets × 8 per leg
- Plank hold: 2 × 15 seconds

Golden Rules

1. ****Never train through sharp pain**** — dull ache during exercise is acceptable
2. ****Apply the 24-hour rule****: if a joint is more swollen or painful 24 hours after exercise, you did too much
3. ****Warm up first****: 5 minutes of gentle movement
4. ****Rest days**

matter:** allow 48 hours between sessions for the same muscle group\n\n*Programme by Sarah Mitchell, MCSP, HCPC Registered Physiotherapist*



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What the Evidence Says

Extensive high-quality research shows that regular strength training is incredibly beneficial for people living with various forms of arthritis. Systematic reviews, which combine results from many different studies, consistently find that strengthening exercises lead to significant reductions in pain, improved physical function, and a better quality of life. These benefits are seen across different joints and types of arthritis.

Clinical guidelines from leading rheumatology organisations universally recommend incorporating strength training into arthritis management plans. These recommendations are based on strong evidence from randomised controlled trials, which are considered the gold standard in medical research. They show that supervised, progressive resistance exercise is not only effective but also safe when performed correctly.

The improvements aren't just about feeling better; studies also indicate that strengthening muscles around arthritic joints can slow down disease progression in some cases, by stabilising the joint and helping to protect the cartilage from further wear and tear.



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Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Starting too heavy too soon:** Begin with easily manageable weights or bodyweight to establish good form. * **Holding your breath:** Breathe out during the effort part of the

exercise and in during the recovery. * **Skipping warm-ups or cool-downs:** Always prepare your body and gently wind down to prevent stiffness. * **Only focusing on one muscle group:** Aim for a balanced programme that works all major muscle groups. * **Not listening to your body:** Differentiate between muscle fatigue and joint pain. If a joint hurts, stop.

When to Speak to a Clinician

While strength training is generally very safe and beneficial, there are times when it's really important to get advice from a healthcare professional. If you experience new or worsening symptoms that are beyond what you'd expect from typical muscle soreness, or if you're uncertain about how to exercise safely with your particular type of arthritis, please reach out to your doctor, physiotherapist, or rheumatologist.



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You should seek advice if you experience: * Sudden, severe joint pain that doesn't settle. * Increased joint swelling, redness, or warmth that lasts more than 24 hours. * New numbness, tingling, or weakness in a limb. * Pain that wakes you up at night or is present at rest. * Difficulty performing daily tasks due to exercise-related joint issues.

Frequently Asked Questions

How often should I lift weights if I have arthritis? For most people, two to three sessions per week targeting the major muscle groups is ideal. This allows sufficient time for muscle recovery and adaptation, which is crucial for building strength and preventing overuse.

Can strength training make my arthritis worse? When done correctly and progressively, strength training is highly unlikely to make your arthritis worse. In fact, it typically improves symptoms. The key is to start gently, listen to your body, and never push through sharp pain, always respecting the 24-hour rule.

Do I need to buy special equipment for strength training? Not at all! Many effective strength exercises can be done using just your body weight, such as squats, lunges, and push-ups against a wall. Resistance bands are also an excellent, affordable way to add challenge, and household items like full water bottles can serve as light weights.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about strength training with arthritis: a beginner's safe start guide?

Short answer: Strength training is beneficial for arthritis, reducing pain and improving function. A beginner programme could include wall push-ups, seated leg extensions, and resistance band rows for weeks 1–2. Progress to chair squats and step-ups in weeks 3–4. Always warm up, avoid training through sharp pain, and allow 48 hours rest between sessions for the same muscle group.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk